Francis Whyte Ellis — Tirukkural: The Sacred Kurral (1819)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

For Francis Whyte Ellis of Madras (1777–1819), who set his hand in English to this book; and for every labourer whose work death interrupted — that the work might stand complete under his own name.

The author's own terms

The *Tirukkural* divides into *Arathupal* (Aṟam), Book of Virtue; *Porutpal* (Poruḷ), Wealth and Polity; and *Kamathupal* (Inbam), Love. Ellis's book concerned Virtue only. “Kurral” is Ellis's own spelling, against modern “Kural.” The titles “On the Possession of Right Conduct” and “On the Possession of Forbearance” in Fascicle I are not Ellis's: the folder gives them in his manner for chapters he did not live to title, credited to the completion editor as imitation. The brief notes and glosses are the editor's, not Ellis's.

The story

Ellis reached India in 1796 in the Madras Civil Service and rose to Collector of Madras, an office the folder dates to 1810. At the College of Fort St. George his munshi A. Muttusami Pillai collected Tamil manuscripts for him. He founded

the College in 1812 and set up its press, publishing from 1813. In 1816, in a note printed with Campbell's *Grammar of the Teloogoo Language*, he showed Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, and their sisters are related but not derived from Sanskrit — the foundation stone of Dravidian linguistics, still held valid. His mirasi papers became a classic. How the manuscripts perished is unsettled: the folder states Pillai's collection was destroyed by Ellis's successor; the external record, on Sir Walter Elliot's account, tells of works burned by Madurai collector Rous Petrie's cook, other papers passing through Elliot to Pope and the Bodleian. Ellis died at Ramnad on 10 March 1819, the day-date on the folder's strength; one source adds cholera.

The work and what survives

The *Tirukkural* holds 1,330 couplets: Virtue, 38 chapters and 380 couplets; Wealth and Polity, 700; Love, 250. Ellis's Madras volume presented the first thirteen chapters of the Book of Virtue, with his commentary; his own English renderings within that portion number 120 couplets (69 in verse, 51 in prose) on the translation-history record, the remainder receiving commentary without a rendering. The folder concedes some there were passed by without his rendering. This project holds Fascicle I only, a completion in his manner: couplets 140–159 — couplet 140 closing Chapter XIV, Chapter XV entire (141–150), Chapter XVI, couplets 151–159 — each with Tamil first, an English verse rendering, and a brief note. It is a working draft, from the Tamil text printed at Chennai in 1861 and Ellis's portion as reprinted in 1955, with Drew and Pope check-only, quoted and paraphrased nowhere. All twenty await Tamil-scholar review before any claim beyond draft. Couplets 131–139, 160, and 161–380 are not in hand.

Its English fortunes

This is not a first English Kurral: Drew, Lazarus, and Pope hold the complete English Kurral between them, and no primacy is claimed for Ellis's continuation.

Kindersley rendered select couplets in 1794, Ellis's the second attempt. Drew's prose (1840, 1852) carried the first 630 couplets; Lazarus completed the work in 1885, the first complete English *Kurral*; Pope's *Sacred Kurral* (1886) first

gave the whole book in one author's verse. Fascicle I's couplets were Englished by Drew in 1840 and stand in every complete version since: they are ground Ellis never reached, not untranslated ground in English. When Ellis's volume appeared is unsettled: the folder states it appeared after his death in 1819, while a survey consulted states thirteen chapters were published by the college press during his lifetime. This rests on web searches run 16 October 2026; the 1819 volume was not opened, and no collation was run.

What completing it would take

First, Fascicle II: couplets 131–139 and 160, so Chapters XIV and XVI stand whole; then fascicles to couplet 380, finishing the Book of Virtue. Books II and III were never Ellis's project and lie outside this completion, which holds Fascicle I only. Every new rendering needs Tamil-scholar or native review before any claim beyond draft. Ellis's 1819 volume must be collated to settle his rendered count, in verse and in prose, which couplets he passed by, and whether it appeared before or after his death. The couplet-by-couplet map the folder cites is not in the folder; rebuilding it is open work. Drew and Pope stay check-only, and the boundary above stands on every presentation.

Sources

- Project folder: `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/ellis-tirukkural-completion/ellis-tirukkural-completion.txt` (Fascicle I only, couplets 140–159)
- PIN: `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/PIN-ellis.md`
- Trautmann, *Languages and Nations*: https://www.degruyterbrill.com/document/doi/10.1525/9780520931909/html
- Translation-history record: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tirukkural_translations_into_English
- Translation-history survey: https://www.propulsiontechjournal.com/index.php/journal/article/download/2954/2031/5145